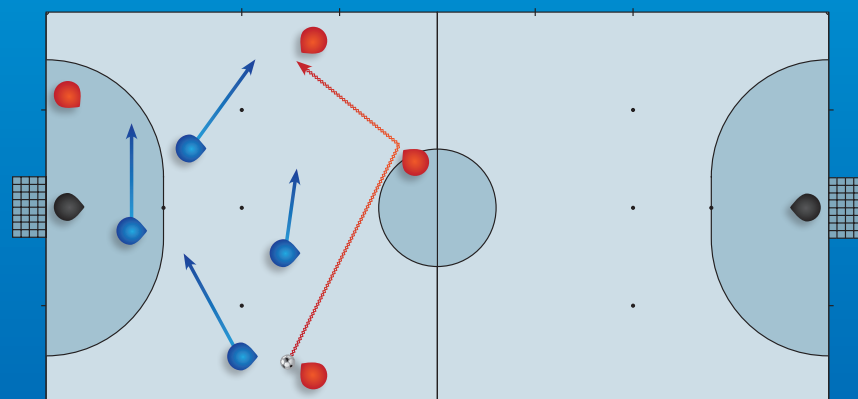


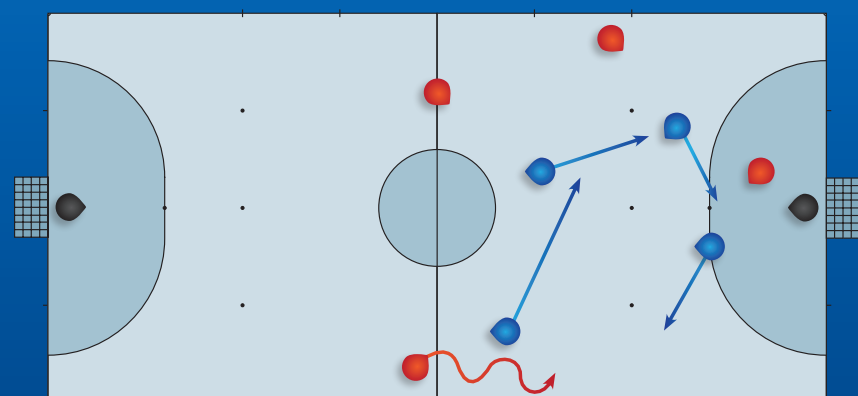
Defensive movement as one single unit

33



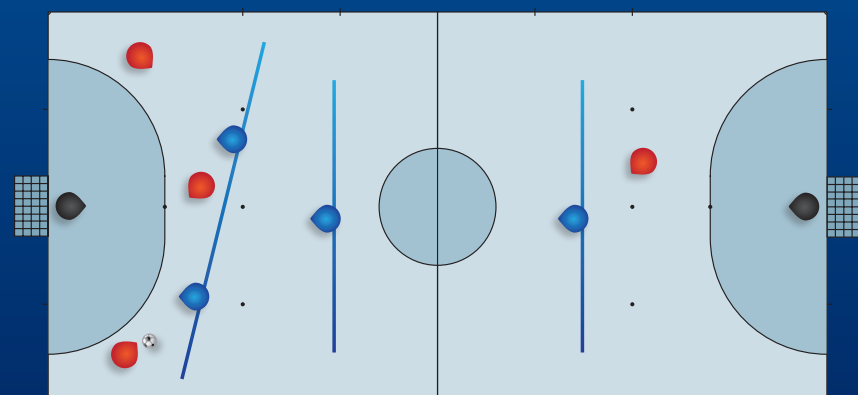
Defensive rotation with four players

34



Defensive lines

35



1.5.3.2 Defensive team tactics

Group tactical defensive options: some of these tactical options have already been discussed in the section on small-group technical/tactical options. Due to their global nature, these options can also be applied to team tactics, as they represent core tactical concepts that the team possess in addition to the core concepts imparted by the coach.

- **Defensive movement as one single unit:** this is a move executed by the defence in unison, with players moving together as a single unit in response to a change in the position of the ball. The objective is to maintain the distance between lines of defence and the covering system.

- **Defensive rotation:** the movement executed by defensive players when covering and switching in order to readjust the position of the defence. When these moves are executed in a specific order, with players rotating in the same direction, they are called defensive rotations of two, three or four players.

- **Defensive reorganisation:** whenever the defence is pulled out of position, several changes of marker or position are sometimes necessary in order to reorganise it.

- **Rational occupation of defensive space:** regardless of the defensive system employed, the defensive space must be occupied in a rational and logical way, making use of small-group and individual technical/tactical options: e.g. commanding the space, floating cover, etc. Rational occupation of space also involves maximising the number of defensive lines.

- **Changing the type of defence:** game situations where the type of defence is modified during play, because there is a need to change things up or to confuse the opponent.

- **Changing tactical defensive objectives:** this can involve a change in intensity, organisation, or rational occupation of space, executed by the defence at a given moment in the game.
- **Defensive wall:** this is a technical/tactical option that can include between one and four players (or even five if the goalkeeper joins it), depending on the position of the free-kick.

Defensive phases of play: we are already aware of the defensive phases of play (positional balance and buying time, dropping back, defensive organisation and positional defence). Team tactics take into account all of these phases and the use of the core concepts and options required for each one.

Tactical processes involving four outfield players: the linking-together of various defensive technical/tactical options by the team as a whole.

Defensive systems of play: these will be covered in greater depth in the next section. As already stated with regard to attacking systems, they do not strictly fall under the category of team tactics, but we highlight them in the sense that the tactical movements and procedures used to maintain and execute them are tactical options.

Types of defence: provides a framework so that the team understands how to respond to attacking movements. Specific attention must be paid to the position of the ball and the opponents, the space on the court and the passing angles.

1. **Man-marking system:** in this type of defence, the defenders have an individual responsibility for the attacker whom they are marking.
2. **Zonal system:** the players are responsible for a specified area of play depending on the location of the ball. Each defender is responsible for the attackers who pass through their zone, as well as for closing down the passing angles in this area of play.
3. **Mixed system:** a type of defence where man-marking and zonal systems are combined, with some players marking a player and others defending a zone.
4. **Switching system:** in a switching defence, defenders continually switch between marking different opponents in a system involving continuous covering and switching. The objective is that the first line of defence does not drop back in relation to the ball. Both the wingers and the defender are required to pick up the players that drop short with or without the ball. This system involves a man-marking defence where defenders switch markers according to the guidelines given by the coach. Generally speaking, this is a defensive system that combines positive aspects of both the man-marking and zonal systems. The guidelines for the switches can be founded on the making of decisions based on the game situation (e.g. pressing the ball, position of the opponent, direction of play, etc.) or can be based on clearly defined and more specific instructions from the coach.

Advantages and disadvantages of the man-marking system

Advantages

- Easy for players to learn (clear who is responsible for what).
- Greater focus, easy system to learn.
- Attacker is not given the time to think.
- Effective when facing technically limited teams.

Disadvantages

- More difficult to provide cover.
- Less teamwork between players.
- Allows the attacking team to create passing angles.
- More physically demanding.
- Individual errors are more costly.

Advantages and disadvantages of the zonal system

Advantages

- Less physically demanding as players cover for each other more.
- Allows the team to use players who are weaker defensively.
- Opposition players are forced to think more as passing angles have been closed down.
- Provides simple transition to counter-attack.

Disadvantages

- Detailed strategy requiring several instructions to develop the defensive system.
- Requires a great deal of communication and teamwork between players.
- Demands players with a good understanding of defensive tactics.
- Allows the opposition to create numerical advantages in attack which the team must know how to defend against.